cholesterol includes animal foods. It is used in the body for synthesizing hormones, Vitamin D and substances which help to digest foods. High blood cholesterol is a risk factor for heart disease. Rich sources of dietary cholesterol include meat, poultry (with skin), organ meats like brain, kidney, liver and full fat dairy products.

(ii) **Fatty acids:** They are the key refined fuel form of fat that the cell burns for energy. They are the basic structural unit of fats and they may be saturated or unsaturated. (e.g) oleic acid, linoleic acid, linolenic acid, palmitic acid and myristic acid.

10.10.2 On the basis of fatty acids

Fats can be classified based on the fatty acids present in them as follows:

1) Saturated fatty acids

A saturated fat is a type of fat in which the fatty acid chains have all or predominantly single bonds. Various fats contain different proportions of saturated fat. Saturated fatty acids, especially palmitic and stearic acids are found in animal products such as cream, cheese, butter, other whole milk dairy products and fatty meats which also contain dietary cholesterol. Certain vegetable products have high saturated fat content, such as coconut oil and palm kernel oil. Many prepared foods are high in saturated fat content, such as pizza, dairy desserts and sausage.

2) Unsaturated fatty acids

An unsaturated fat is a fat or fatty acid in which there is at least one double bond within the fatty acid chain.

(i) **Monounsaturated fatty acid (MUFA):** A fatty acid chain is monounsaturated if it contains one double bond. Monounsaturated fats are good fats. A diet high in MUFA can reduce blood cholesterol levels, lowers risk of heart disease, stroke and breast cancer, reduces pain in rheumatoid arthritis and helps in



Fig 10.14: Food sources of Saturated fats

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